

Chapter 101-2

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The city entered into nighttime. On the asphalt roads, vehicles came and went, red taillights crisscrossing and lighting up throughout the city. The streetlamps on both sides of the road illuminated the way home for people hurrying along.

Ling Dang slept peacefully on Liang Shi's lap as Liang Xinzhou drove Liang Shi back to Chenjiang Community.

Along both banks of the river were dim yellow lights, casting a gentle glow on the flowing water.

The cables spanning the bridge seemed to reach toward the sky. This city was inclusive and beautiful.

They had originally planned to go to the hospital where Qiu Zimin and Guo Xinran were, but Ling Dang was fast asleep, and it was getting late. Liang Shi suggested going home first to avoid having a fight late at night, which would make everyone uncomfortable.

The main reason was to give Liang Xinhe and his wife time to "pull the rug out from under them."¹

Liang Xinzhou also agreed. He dropped her off at the community and asked if she had moved in yet. Liang Shi replied that she would in a while.

When she was about to carry Ling Dang out, Liang Xinzhou told her to leave Ling Dang in the car. Tonight, Ling Dang could stay with him and Yu Wan. Liang Shi hesitated a bit—after all, Yu Wan was pregnant, and she was afraid Ling Dang might disturb her.

So Liang Shi said she would ask Ling Dang's opinion.

Ling Dang was drowsy from sleep. After being woken up, she didn't cry. When she heard Liang Shi ask whether she wanted to go to Auntie's house or back to Uncle's house tonight, Ling Dang rubbed her eyes and asked, "Is Sheng Yu at your house?"

Liang Shi: "...I don't know."

"Then I'm not going." Ling Dang yawned, rather heartlessly. "I want to go find Auntie and play with the little sister in her belly."

Liang Shi: "...Alright then."

After waking Ling Dang up, she didn't let her go back to sleep. The little head huddled in the seat. After reminding Liang Xinzhou to drive carefully, Liang Shi finally headed home.

On her way home, she sent a message to Xu Qingzhu, asking if she had eaten dinner and if she had come back.

After sending the message, she suddenly thought of "roommates sharing a rental." This situation was indeed quite similar.

Living in the same home but in different rooms. The daily questions were: Are you home? Are you at home? What do you want to eat in the morning? What do you want to eat at night?

Occasionally interspersed with some other conversations.

Swaying between crossing the line and not crossing it.

Everything followed the heart's desire. No one deliberately controlled the pace between them, yet occasionally they would rush headlong toward a place where they couldn't stop.

In the moment, it didn't feel like anything was wrong. Instead, her heart would pound, and she could laugh out loud just looking at the screen.

Only afterward would she realize that perhaps she had overstepped.

Standing in the elevator, Liang Shi thought carefully about this issue for the first time.

But she couldn't distinguish where her own feelings stood, or to what degree Xu Qingzhu's feelings had reached.

Was it liking?

Or simply dependence?

Liang Shi was someone extremely skilled at suppressing her own emotions. She had mastered delayed gratification to the extreme.

In that other world, afraid of hurting others, she always had to suppress her emotions. In middle school, when she saw a girl she liked, her first reaction was to stay far away—she wouldn't even have normal conversations with her.

It was the same every time afterward. Even when she met someone she was interested in, she wouldn't take the initiative to greet them. She was exceptionally sensitive and would notice changes in the emotions of people around her.

Because she had always lived this way.

Back then, her manager and assistant both said she lived too cautiously, too carefully—not at all like someone in their twenties.

What should someone in their twenties be like?

Bold and carefree, proud and confident, thinking that no peak in this world was too high, no hardship in this world was too difficult, and nothing could make them retreat.

When doing something, they wouldn't think about how others would feel, but would first consider what they themselves wanted.

But Liang Shi had passed through her twenties without being bold or carefree, without being proud or confident. She was like the most inconspicuous silent pine tree by the roadside—evergreen through all four seasons, always there, yet never noticed by anyone.

Being mature beyond one's years was never something to be glad about.

Manager Sister Wang said Liang Shi was the most worry-free artist she had ever managed.

Assistant Xiao Bai said Liang Shi was the most down-to-earth Best Actress in the entertainment industry.

But Liang Shi's silence only applied to herself. If she was wronged, she would silently endure it.

If she made others uncomfortable, she would actively communicate.

She hoped others wouldn't go to sleep carrying unpleasant emotions.

Once, when Sister Wang heard this, she asked her, "What about you?"

—What about you?

—I've never thought about it.

Liang Shi truly had never thought about this. For her, grievances wouldn't last overnight.

Because no one would carry her grievances, be the trash can she could pour her heart out to, or be her safe harbor.

So she didn't board anyone's ship, yet could still stand brave and resolute in the middle of the ocean, not overturned by the fierce waves.

It was precisely because she was this kind of person that she could understand Liang Xinzhou's current situation, that she could empathize with him.

She would go worship Buddha once a year. Kneeling on the prayer cushion, her wish was always simple: May there be world peace, and may everyone be safe and happy.

Except for the year her grandfather was seriously ill—that time she changed her wish: She hoped her grandfather's illness would get better soon.

Liang Shi still didn't understand her own emotions. She only knew that being with Xu Qingzhu made her happy.

Her whole being would relax.

Because Xu Qingzhu knew all her secrets and had seen her at her worst, she could be herself without restraint in front of Xu Qingzhu.

Only in front of Xu Qingzhu was she still the Liang Shi of before, without needing to live wearing a mask.

Although Zhao Xuning also knew about her situation, they had little interaction, so it wasn't like how she was with Xu Qingzhu.

1. "Pull the rug out from under them" (釜底抽薪): A Chinese idiom literally meaning "to remove the firewood from under the cauldron." It refers to a strategy of removing the source of a problem or cutting off someone's support/resources, thereby fundamentally solving an issue or undermining someone's position. In this context, it means giving Liang Xinhe and his wife time to deal with the root of the problem regarding Qiu Zimin and Guo Xinran. ↩